



The No-Regrets Guide to Kyoto



A Taiwanese Traveler's Honest 7-Day Kyoto Diary

| Kyoto · Nara · Uji · Osaka



Before You Go: Why Kyoto?

Let me be upfront with you: before I went, I was the type of person who rolled their eyes at overly hyped destinations. "Everyone goes to Kyoto — it's probably a tourist trap," I told myself. Then I actually went. And by day two, I was already planning my return trip.

Kyoto is not a city that rushes. It's a city that makes you slow down — whether you want to or not. Around every corner there's a centuries-old shrine, a narrow lane paved with stone, or a café quietly brewing matcha in the morning light. It has a particular magic that photographs can only hint at.

This guide is the real deal: every restaurant, transportation tip, timing strategy, and hidden gem in here comes from seven days of walking until my feet gave out and still not wanting to go home. I've included everything I wish I'd known before going — the good, the surprising, and the occasional face-palm mistake.

No fluff. No "top 10 Instagram spots." Just honest, practical, fun travel knowledge from someone who's been there and is desperate to go back.



7-Day Itinerary at a Glance

Day 1 ► Arrive at Kansai Airport → Kyoto Station

Day 2 ► To-ji → Kinkaku-ji → Arashiyama → Nishiki Market → Gion

Day 3 ► Kiyomizu-dera (dawn) → Hikiniku to Kome queue → Kibune Shrine → Dinner

Day 4 ► Fushimi Inari (dawn) → Nara day trip → Uji matcha

Day 5 ▶ Move to Osaka → Katsuoji Temple → Osaka Castle/Umeda → Dotonbori

Day 6 ▶ Kuromon Market → Tsutenkaku → Shitennoji → Shinsaibashi shopping

Day 7 ▶ Return flight home

DAY 1 | : We're Here. Now What?

17:55 Landing at Kansai International Airport (KIX)

Kansai Airport (KIX) sits on an artificial island in Osaka Bay — the view coming in to land, with water on all sides, already feels like an arrival worth celebrating. Designed by Renzo Piano and opened in 1994, the terminal building itself is an architectural landmark: a sweeping 1.7km arched roof that still looks futuristic three decades later.

But enough sightseeing — you've got things to do before those train gates close. Here's the ideal post-landing checklist, in order:

- ▶ Pick up or purchase an ICOCA card (or SUICA) at the ticket machines — this is your key to all trains and buses throughout the trip
- ▶ Exchange yen cash (airport rates are decent; don't waste time chasing marginally better rates at convenience stores)
- ▶ Confirm your mobile data plan is active — Japan's Google Maps navigation is exceptionally accurate and you'll use it constantly
- ▶ If you have heavy luggage, use the Takkyubin delivery service (1,500–2,000 yen per bag) to send your suitcase directly to your hotel — it arrives next morning and saves you enormous hassle on trains

 Pro tip: Buy the "ICOCA & HARUKA" package in Taiwan before departure. It bundles an ICOCA card with a discounted HARUKA express ticket between the airport and Kyoto/Osaka, saving money and skipping queues on arrival.

19:15 Taking the JR HARUKA Limited Express

The HARUKA is the most direct and comfortable way from Kansai Airport to Kyoto Station — a 75-minute ride with no transfers, spacious seats, and overhead racks that fit large suitcases without the gymnastics required on regular commuter trains.

Book a reserved seat (shiteiseki) rather than the unreserved cars, especially on weekends. It costs a little more but guarantees your spot. First-class Green Car seats are an option too — if you want to start the trip with a little splurge, they're genuinely comfortable.

As the train pulls away from the island and moves through suburban Osaka into Kyoto's basin, use this 75 minutes well: download offline maps for Kyoto and Osaka, screenshot the addresses

of your key destinations, and mentally review tomorrow's game plan. The transition is gradual — sea, then suburbs, then the quiet hum of an ancient city at night.

 Save key addresses in Japanese characters as screenshots. When asking locals for directions or showing taxi drivers, Japanese addresses are much more useful than romanized versions.

20:45 Arriving at Kyoto Station

Kyoto Station will surprise you the first time. You're expecting ancient temples and wooden eaves — and instead you walk into a soaring glass-and-steel structure that looks like a space station. Built in 1997 and designed by Hiroshi Hara, it's deliberately contemporary, housing shopping malls, a food court, a hotel, a department store, and connections to essentially every transport line in the city.

Navigation tip: the south side is called the "Karasuma Exit" (正面口) and the north side is the "Tower Exit" (塔口). Buses, taxis, and most hotels are on the south side. The Kyoto Tower — a relic of 1964 and strangely charming — is directly outside.



Kyoto Tower at night, right outside Kyoto Station

Check in, drop your bags. The first evening's job is simply to arrive, eat something, and get a good night's sleep. Seriously. Resist the urge to "squeeze in" an evening attraction — your feet will need every hour of rest they can get.

Dinner Options: Ramen Street vs. Porta Underground

Two good options right at Kyoto Station, depending on your energy level:

- ▶ Ramen Koji (Ramen Street): On the 10th floor of the Kyoto Station building, a collection of well-known ramen shops from around Japan. First-timers can do a real regional comparison here. Queues at dinner time, but usually worth the 20-minute wait.
- ▶ Porta Underground Mall: Connected directly to the station basement. Restaurants open until 22:00 (last order 21:00–21:30). Less atmosphere than Ramen Street but zero wait time and solid quality across multiple cuisines.
- ▶ Isetan B1 Food Hall: Buy a beautifully packaged bento and snacks, take it back to the hotel, and eat in peace. My personal favorite option after a travel day.

🌙 First night rule: don't overextend. You've just crossed time zones, hauled luggage through two airports, and navigated a foreign train system. A good meal, a hot bath, and 8 hours of sleep is the best possible investment for the days ahead.

DAY 2 | : The Quintessential Kyoto Day

Today is the most landmark-dense day of the trip — five distinct locations spanning ancient temples, bamboo groves, a famous food market, and the heart of geisha culture. It's a long day. Wear comfortable shoes, charge your camera, and embrace the controlled chaos.

08:30 To-ji Temple

To-ji doesn't get the fame it deserves. While tourists rush to Kinkaku-ji, those who start their morning at To-ji are rewarded with one of Kyoto's most beautiful and peaceful scenes: a 57-meter five-story pagoda — the tallest wooden tower in Japan — reflected in a still pond under early morning light, with almost no other visitors in sight.



To-ji's five-story pagoda — Japan's tallest wooden tower (57m)

Built in the early 9th century as part of the original Heian-kyo capital layout, To-ji was entrusted to the monk Kukai (Kobo Daishi), the founder of Shingon Buddhism in Japan. The Kondo (Main Hall) and Kodo (Lecture Hall) contain an extraordinary collection of Esoteric Buddhist statuary — 21 figures arranged as a three-dimensional mandala, each representing a different aspect of the cosmic Buddha. If you have any interest in Buddhist art, this is unmissable.

📷 Best shot: Enter through the main gate, turn left, and find the angle where the five-story pagoda reflects in the garden pond. Morning light from the east hits the wooden structure

perfectly between 8:00–9:00am.

 Admission: 500 yen. On the 21st of each month, the Kobo-san market fills the temple grounds with antiques, crafts, and street food — a wonderful coincidence if your travel dates align.

10:00 Kinkaku-ji (The Golden Pavilion)

Every photo you've seen of Kinkaku-ji does not prepare you for the real thing. The three-story structure, its top two floors covered entirely in gold leaf, reflected in the Mirror Pond (Kyokochi) with manicured pines framing the scene — it stops you mid-step. Even the most cynical traveler finds themselves just standing there, looking.



Kinkaku-ji (The Golden Pavilion) reflected in Mirror Pond

Formally named Rokuon-ji, the pavilion was originally built in 1397 as the retirement villa of Shogun Ashikaga Yoshimitsu. After his death it became a Zen temple. The current structure is a 1955 reconstruction — the original was burned down in 1950 by a young monk, an event that novelist Yukio Mishima turned into the famous novel "The Temple of the Golden Pavilion" (worth reading before or after your visit).

The three floors reflect three distinct architectural styles: the ground floor in Shinden-zukuri (Heian aristocratic style), the second floor in Bukke-zukuri (samurai style), and the top floor in Zen Buddhist style. It's an architectural conversation across centuries, all in one small building

over a pond.

⚠ The viewing route is one-way and crowd-managed. Follow the path and you'll see everything without getting lost. Allow about 45–60 minutes for the full circuit.

❄ Winter secret: if it snowed the night before, the gold-and-white contrast of Kinkaku-ji under fresh snow is considered one of the most beautiful sights in all of Japan. Check the forecast — it's worth timing your visit for the day after snowfall.

13:00 Arashiyama

Arashiyama is Kyoto's other signature landscape, and it earns the reputation. The Bamboo Grove — a narrow 200-meter corridor of towering moso bamboo filtering the light into something luminous and otherworldly — is justifiably one of the most photographed places in Japan.

The honest caveat: in the afternoon, the Bamboo Grove is crowded. Getting a photo without other tourists requires either very early morning timing (6–7am is serene) or patient angle-work. But here's the thing: don't let the crowds stop you from going. The sound of wind through the bamboo, the filtered light, the sheer height of the stalks — it's an experience that transcends any photo, crowded or not.

Beyond the bamboo, Arashiyama offers:

- ▶ Tenryu-ji Garden: A UNESCO World Heritage landscape garden, one of the finest examples of the karesansui (dry landscape) style. Separate admission fee, 100% worth it.
- ▶ Togetsukyo Bridge: The 155-meter bridge over the Oi River with forested mountains behind it is Arashiyama's most iconic view — especially beautiful in late afternoon light.
- ▶ Arashiyama's shopping street: Local crafts, bamboo products, tofu desserts, and every kind of Japanese snack you can imagine. Budget 500–800 yen for walking snacks.

🍡 Must-try in Arashiyama: tofu soft serve ice cream (delicate, slightly bitter, nothing like what "tofu" suggests), grilled mochi skewers (150–200 yen, fresh off the grill), and the wide variety of matcha sweets in every shop window.

16:00 Nishiki Market

Called "Kyoto's Kitchen," Nishiki Market is a 400-meter covered market lane just five blocks wide, lined on both sides with more than 100 specialty food vendors. Pickled vegetables, fresh tofu, Kyoto-style dashi, grilled seafood on skewers, tamago-yaki — it's a textbook of Kyoto food culture compressed into a single alley.

The correct way to experience Nishiki is to graze: pick up one or two items at each stall, eat as you walk, and let your stomach make the decisions. The free tastings are generous and the vendors are generally happy to let you try before you buy.

- ▶ Critical timing: most cooked food stalls start closing between 17:00–17:30. Arrive by 16:30 at the latest to eat freely.
- ▶ It gets very congested between 15:00–17:00 — don't bring oversized luggage; the lane is only about 3 meters wide.
- ▶ Some stalls close on Wednesdays or Sundays — check ahead if you're shopping for a specific item.



Best souvenirs from Nishiki: Sairiku's senmaizuke (paper-thin salted turnip pickles, a Kyoto classic), various vacuum-packed pickled vegetable sets, and fresh miso from the specialty miso shops. Far better selection and price than airport stores.

Evening Gion

From Nishiki, walk east across the Kamo River on Shijo Bridge, and you'll enter Gion — Kyoto's most atmospheric district and the heartland of geisha culture for over 300 years. The stone-paved Hanamikoji Street, with its preserved ochaya (teahouses) and soft amber lighting after sunset, creates a mood that's impossible to replicate anywhere else.

About geisha: many visitors come to Gion hoping to see real geiko (the Kyoto term for geisha) or maiko (apprentices). They do exist here, but their appearances are unpredictable. The "maiko" you'll most commonly see are tourists in rental kimono costumes, which is perfectly fun but different from the real thing. Real geiko and maiko are rushing to and from engagements in the evening and generally prefer not to be photographed. If you're genuinely interested in experiencing geisha arts, look into ticketed cultural performances through hotels or arts organizations — you'll see far more than any street encounter.

Gion dinner suggestion: the neighborhood has excellent izakayas at the 2,000–4,000 yen per person range, where you can drink cold Sapporo or Asahi and eat yakitori and small plates while the evening settles around you. This is Kyoto at its most livable.



Important note: Hanamikoji Street has rules against eating while walking and against loud behavior. These exist to protect local residents and the cultural environment. Please respect them.



DAY 3 | : Dawn at Kiyomizu • The Hikiniku Mission • Kibune Shrine

Today requires the most strategic planning of the entire trip. Everything revolves around the Hikiniku to Kome time-slot ticket system. Here's how to make it all work perfectly:

06:00 Kiyomizu-dera — The Temple at Dawn

Kiyomizu-dera receives over 3 million visitors a year and is one of Japan's most popular tourist sites. On a busy afternoon, it can feel more like a theme park than a sacred site. But here's the secret that changes everything: Kiyomizu-dera opens at 6:00am.

At 6 o'clock in the morning, particularly in winter, you might be one of only a handful of people on the grounds. The famous wooden stage (butai) cantilevers out over the hillside, supported entirely by wooden pillars without a single nail. On a clear morning, you stand on that stage and look out over Kyoto's basin — rooftops, distant mountains, morning mist slowly burning off — in near-complete silence. It's one of those travel moments that becomes a core memory.

The temple's main hall enshrines a Thousand-Armed Kannon (Bodhisattva of Compassion), revealed to the public only once every 33 years — next in 2033. What's visible now is the "mae-

dachi" (front-standing) figure. Take time to move through the main hall slowly, rather than rushing for the stage photo.

From Kiyomizu-dera, walk down the slope through Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka — the best-preserved Edo-period streetscape in Kyoto. At 6am, with shops still shuttered and no tourists yet, the stone-paved lanes are extraordinarily atmospheric. Walk toward Yasaka Shrine, and you're already 5 minutes from Hikiniku to Kome.



Kiyomizu-dera — UNESCO World Heritage Site

👣 The stone steps of Sannenzaka are beautiful but genuinely slippery when wet, especially

in winter. There's an old superstition that falling here brings three years of bad luck — probably invented by someone who fell and needed an explanation. Wear shoes with grip.

📷 Best photo of Kiyomizu-dera: walk around to the Okuno-in Hall platform, which gives you the classic view of the wooden stage extending from the main hall against the forested hillside. Golden morning light from the east makes this the best time to shoot it.

08:00 Hikiniku to Kome — The Queue Strategy

Hikiniku to Kome is arguably the most sought-after restaurant in Kyoto right now. It serves a single item: Hamburg steak set meal. But calling it a "hamburger" is like calling Kinkaku-ji a "building." The experience is entirely different.

Here's what they do: fresh beef mince, ground that day, is hand-shaped into a sphere in front of you and placed directly on the iron griddle. You watch it cook. The exterior caramelizes to a dark crust while the inside stays outrageously juicy. Cut it open and the steam alone makes everyone at the table lean forward. Served with a clay-pot rice (perfectly cooked, fragrant, free refills), handmade miso soup, and pickles — the whole set costs around 1,650–1,980 yen and represents one of the best value-per-experience meals in the country.

The system: there are no online reservations. Time-slot tickets are issued in person each morning, and the number of slots available equals the number of diners they can serve. Early arrivals get their choice of time; late arrivals get whatever's left.

- ▶ Walk from Yasaka Shrine to the restaurant: about 5 minutes
- ▶ Arrive by 8:00am — you'll likely find a line already formed
- ▶ Staff will confirm available time slots as the queue grows
- ▶ Secure a 17:00 dinner slot — this gives you the entire day for Kibune Shrine
- ▶ Once you have the ticket, you're free until your dinner time

📍 Hikiniku to Kome — Gion Branch

Location: Higashiyama Ward, Kyoto (5 min walk from Yasaka Shrine)

Ticket system: In-person queue only — no reservations accepted

Recommended arrival: before 8:00am

Price: Hamburg set approx. 1,650–1,980 yen per person

⚠️ There is also a Kyoto Station branch — both require the same queue system

Morning to Afternoon Kibune Shrine — Mountain Water Sanctuary

With your dinner time secured and the whole day free, Kibune Shrine is the perfect destination. It's off the typical tourist radar, deeply atmospheric, and genuinely worth the journey.

Kibune Shrine sits in a mountain valley 10km north of Kyoto's city center, a 40–50 minute trip combining subway and the Eizan Electric Railway (a charmingly narrow single-track mountain line that winds through forest). The shrine is dedicated to Takaokami-no-kami, the deity of

water — one of the most fundamental forces in an agricultural civilization.

The approach to the main shrine (Hongu) is one of Kyoto's most beautiful paths: stone lanterns line both sides of the steep steps leading upward, and the red-painted wooden shrine buildings contrast with the dark forest around them. In winter, if there's snow, the lanterns and snow together create a scene of extraordinary beauty that even seasoned Japan travelers describe as the most memorable thing they've seen.



Kibune Shrine stone-lantern staircase

Three areas to visit:

- ▶ Hongu (Main Shrine): The heart of the complex, where you can draw a "water divination" fortune (mizuura omikuji) — a slip of paper that looks blank until you lower it into the stream, where your fortune appears in ink. It's genuinely magical.
- ▶ Yui-no-Yashiro (Middle Shrine): One of Japan's three great love shrines, dedicated to Iwanaga-hime. The ema (votive plaques) here are covered in love wishes written in Japanese, Korean, Chinese, and English.
- ▶ Okumiya (Inner Shrine): The oldest and most remote section, reached by continuing further up the valley. More secluded and serene.

❄ Mountain temperatures in Kibune run 5–8°C colder than Kyoto city in winter. Bring an extra layer — it's not comfortable to rush through a beautiful shrine while shivering.

17:00 Hikiniku to Kome — The Payoff

A full day of anticipation, and now the moment arrives. Your server leads you to a seat at the iron griddle. You watch the chef take the day's fresh beef mince, work it gently between their palms — no squeezing, no pressing, just enough shaping to form a sphere — and place it on the heated surface.

The sizzle. The smell. The slow transformation from pink to deep mahogany. When the Hamburg steak is ready, you cut into it and the interior is steaming, rose-colored, and unbelievably juicy. Every element of the set is calibrated: the clay-pot rice sweet and slightly sticky, the miso soup deep and round, the pickles bright and acidic.

There's a reason people queue at 8am for this. After eating it, you'll understand completely.

DAY 4 | : Torii Tunnels • Nara • Uji Matcha Marathon

Three destinations in three different directions — this is the logistically intensive day. But each one is completely different in character, making it the most varied day of the entire trip. Pre-download your transit routes the night before.

06:00 Fushimi Inari Taisha — The Tunnel at Dawn

Fushimi Inari Taisha is the head shrine of more than 32,000 Inari shrines across Japan. Dedicated to the kami of rice, sake, industry, and prosperity, it has been a place of pilgrimage for over 1,300 years. The thousands of vermilion torii gates winding up Mount Inari — donated by merchants and individuals over the centuries as offerings of gratitude — form one of the most visually stunning landscapes in the world.

The gate corridors are genuinely awe-inspiring in both directions: looking forward into the tunnel they create, and looking back at the view of Kyoto through the spaces between. The gates glow an almost otherworldly orange in morning light.

At 6:00am, the mountain is yours. No crowds. No tour groups. Just the gates, the birdsong, and

the light filtering through in diagonal shafts. This is the version of Fushimi Inari that the daytime tourist photos can only approximate.



Fushimi Inari — the iconic torii tunnel at dawn

- ▶ Full summit hike: 2–3 hours round trip (strenuous but very satisfying)



Kyoto basin panorama from Yotsutsuji on the mountain trail

- ▶ Yotsutsuji (halfway point): 40–50 minutes up, panoramic view of Kyoto city — this is where most people sensibly stop
- ▶ Just the gate corridors near the base: 20–30 minutes, still spectacular

🦊 The fox (kitsune) throughout the shrine grounds is not worshipped as a deity but serves as the messenger of the Inari kami. Look for the stone foxes at each sub-shrine holding symbolic objects in their mouths: a key (to the rice granary), a jewel, or a sheaf of rice. Each one tells you something about what that particular shrine is dedicated to.

🕒 Fushimi Inari is open 24 hours with no admission fee. After the dawn visit, take the JR Nara Line back to Kyoto Station — the train runs from Inari Station just outside the shrine grounds.

Morning Nara Day Trip

From Kyoto Station, take the Kintetsu Kyoto Line limited express (kyuko) directly to Kintetsu Nara Station — about 35–45 minutes and very straightforward. (Note: the JR route requires transfers; Kintetsu is simpler and comparable in time.)

Todai-ji Temple

Todai-ji's Great Buddha Hall (Daibutsuden) is the largest wooden structure in the world. Walking through the Nandaimon gate — flanked by two colossal 8.4-meter guardian figures carved in 1203, all fierce energy and billowing robes — you get your first sense of the scale of what's ahead.

Inside the hall: the Vairocana Buddha (Rushanabutsu) sits at 15 meters tall, cast in bronze in the 8th century. Standing before it, you understand why it required an estimated 2.6 million workers over 10 years to build. The two flanking Bodhisattvas, the four Guardian Kings in the corners, the lanterns the size of small rooms — the entire interior is calibrated for maximum spiritual impact.

One quirky must-do: near the back of the hall is a wooden column with a hole at its base, the same size as one of the Great Buddha's nostrils. Legend says that anyone who can pass through this hole will be blessed with wisdom and enlightenment. There's always a small crowd attempting it, mostly children and adventurous adults. It's surprisingly fun.

Nara Park and the Famous Deer

Approximately 1,000–1,300 sika deer roam freely through Nara Park, designated as national natural monuments. They have coexisted with the city for over 1,300 years, traditionally regarded as divine messengers of the Kasuga Grand Shrine. They know this. The deer of Nara walk with a confidence bordering on entitlement.



Nara Park: a sika deer takes ownership of a bench

Shika-senbei (deer crackers) are sold throughout the park for around 200 yen per bundle. The moment you produce them, you will be surrounded. The deer have learned to bow their heads when you bow to them — it's a genuinely delightful interaction, and the timing between bows can stretch out for surprisingly long stretches.

🦌 Deer etiquette: hide your crackers until you're ready to feed, or you'll be mobbed immediately. They're not dangerous but will nudge, nibble, and occasionally headbutt bags in search of hidden food. Male deer with antlers (non-shedding period outside January–

March) require a bit more personal space.

Afternoon Uji — Matcha Pilgrimage

From Nara, take the Kintetsu or JR back to Uji — about 40–50 minutes. Uji has been Japan's premier green tea growing region since the Heian period, and the entire town carries the faint, beautiful smell of dried tea leaves. If you've ever wondered what matcha smells like straight from the source, this is it.

Byodoin Temple

The Phoenix Hall of Byodoin is the building on the back of Japan's 10-yen coin — and seeing the real version after years of glimpsing it in your wallet delivers a genuine jolt of recognition. Built in 1053, it represents the Pure Land Buddhist concept of the Western Paradise: a symmetrical building with "wings" extending from both sides, reflected symmetrically in the Aji Pond before it. The proportion, the reflection, the forested hills behind — it's architectural perfection.



Byodo-in Temple, Uji — on the back of the ¥10 coin

The Hoo-do (Phoenix Hall) interior enshrines the Amida Nyorai statue, created by master Buddhist sculptor Jocho — the only confirmed surviving work of his hand. The adjacent Hoshokan museum houses the original decorative phoenix sculptures from the roof (replicas now cap the building) and countless other treasures.

Nakamura Tokichi — Matcha Sweets

For Uji matcha desserts, Nakamura Tokichi is the essential stop. Founded in the late Edo period (1854), this 170-year-old tea merchant is the reference point for Uji tea culture. Both the main store (next to JR Uji Station) and the Byodoin branch are excellent.



Nakamura Tokichi signature matcha dessert, Uji

The signature dessert is the Namacha Zeri (生茶ゼリイ): matcha tea jelly in a bamboo vessel, layered with red bean paste, shiratama rice dumplings, and sweet chestnuts. The matcha has genuine depth and bitterness that grocery-store matcha desserts can only imitate. The bamboo container presentation makes it feel like a ceremony.

Also worth taking home: loose leaf gyokuro or high-grade matcha powder, bought directly from the source. Considerably better quality and price than what you'll find at airports.

Uji Matcha Spots Ranked

Nakamura Tokichi ▶ 170-year-old institution, namacha zeri is unmissable

Tsuen Tea (宇治橋 Tsuen) ▶ The oldest tea shop in Japan (established 1160!), near Uji Bridge

Tsuji Rihei Honten ▶ High-quality matcha soft serve, excellent tea selection to buy

Recommendation: if budget allows, try all three — snacking your way through Uji is the correct approach

DAY 5 | : Moving to Osaka • Daruma Overload • City Energy

Today is the pivot point: leaving the ancient, contemplative world of Kyoto and moving into the loud, generous, food-obsessed energy of Osaka. The distance is only 40 minutes by train, but culturally it's a different planet.

Morning Moving to Osaka

From Kyoto, take the Hankyu Kyoto Line (toward Umeda/Osaka) or JR to arrive in central Osaka in about 30–40 minutes. Drop luggage at your hotel (most allow early luggage storage before check-in time), and head out light.

The contrast between Kyoto and Osaka is one of Japan's great cultural tensions. Kyoto is introverted, traditional, aware of its own dignity. Osaka is extroverted, commercial, irreverent. Osaka people (Osakans) have a reputation for being the friendliest, most direct, and funniest people in Japan. If you ask for directions, a Kyoto person will give you perfectly polite instructions. An Osaka person might just walk you there.

This is also your first chance to experience the famous Osaka food culture — tachigui (standing and eating), street snacks, the general philosophy that food should be abundant, affordable, and delicious. The city's informal motto, "kuidaore" (eat until you drop), is not a slogan. It's a lifestyle.

10:30–14:00 Katsuoji Temple — The Daruma Dimension

Katsuoji Temple is the hidden gem of this entire itinerary — something that most tourists skip but everyone who visits remembers. Tucked into the forested hills of Mino Park north of Osaka, Katsuoji is renowned for katsuu (winning/overcoming), drawing pilgrims before exams, athletic competitions, business ventures, and life challenges.

What makes it visually unlike any other temple in Japan: the daruma. Thousands and thousands of daruma figures — the rotund, eyeless Bodhidharma dolls — are tucked into every corner, alcove, step, and tree root throughout the entire temple complex. They line the staircases, fill

niches in the retaining walls, cluster on tabletops in the halls. It looks like an army of small round Buddhas has occupied the mountainside.



Katsuoji Temple — thousands of victory daruma line every surface

Each daruma represents a wish in progress. The Japanese daruma tradition: when making a wish, paint in one eye of the daruma. When the wish is fulfilled, paint in the other eye, then return the daruma to a temple to rest with the thousands of others whose wishes have come true. The result at Katsuoji is an accidental art installation of impossible density — every daruma is someone's hope, in some stage of its journey.

 Katsuoji bus service has limited frequency. Check the return schedule before heading up — missing a bus means a much longer wait than you want.

 Practical info: from Osaka Metro Midosuji Line, take the Kitaosaka Kyuko to Senri-Chuo, then bus to Katsuoji, about 20–25 minutes. The bus stop is right outside the temple entrance.

Afternoon Osaka Castle or Umeda Sky Building

Back in the city, choose your evening based on preference:

Option A: Osaka Castle

One of Japan's three great castles, Osaka Castle (Osaka-jo) was the power base of Toyotomi Hideyoshi, the warlord who unified Japan in the late 16th century. The current tenshu (main keep) is a 1931 ferro-concrete reconstruction, but the white and gold exterior faithfully preserves the traditional castle aesthetic, and the interior museum tells the story of the Sengoku period and Hideyoshi's rise with impressive thoroughness.

The surrounding moats, stone walls, and parkland are authentic — some of the most impressive castle defensive architecture in Japan. The park is gorgeous in spring (cherry blossoms) but beautiful in winter too, with the castle dramatic against a winter sky. Best visited late afternoon for the light.

Option B: Umeda Sky Building

Designed by Hiroshi Hara and completed in 1993, the Umeda Sky Building is two 40-story towers linked at the top by a circular "Floating Garden Observatory" that you access via a transparent escalator escalating through open sky between the towers. The design is deliberately vertiginous — and the 360-degree view from the top, especially after dark when Osaka's grid of lights stretches to the horizon, is extraordinary.

Arrive around 17:00, nurse a hot drink while waiting for the lights to come on, and stay until the city is fully illuminated. It's one of Osaka's signature experiences.

Dinner Okonomiyaki & Dotonbori

Okonomiyaki — the Osaka "pancake" of cabbage, batter, meat or seafood, topped with sweet-savory sauce, mayonnaise, bonito flakes, and dried seaweed — is the city's most iconic food. At a good teppanyaki izakaya, you watch it cooked before you (or cook it yourself). The bonito flakes dancing in the steam from the griddle are almost hypnotic.

After dinner, walk to Dotonbori. The Glico running man sign, the giant crab claws of Kani Doraku, the neon reflections in the canal — Dotonbori at night is every Japanese city-at-night cliché made real and actually thrilling. Walk the canal promenade, people-watch from the bridge, eat takoyaki from a street stall. This is Osaka's maximum energy.



DAY 6 | : Osaka's Full Power

Morning Kuromon Ichiba (Kuromon Market)

If Nishiki is Kyoto's Kitchen, Kuromon is Osaka's. The two markets have entirely different personalities: Nishiki is refined, specialized, tidy; Kuromon is louder, rawer, and proudly obsessed with seafood.

Kuromon runs 580 meters and has been operating since the early 19th century. The key feature: most stalls will open, clean, and serve you their products on-site. You buy a scallop and eat it standing at the stall. You pick a crab leg, they crack it for you, you eat it in the alley. You order sea urchin (uni), they hand it to you in a small dish with a bamboo spoon.

- Oysters: Fresh, enormous, opened to order — 300–500 yen each
- Snow crab legs: Pre-cracked and ready to eat, sweet and clean-tasting
- Uni (sea urchin): If you've never had really fresh uni, this is the place. Expect to spend 1,500–3,000 yen for a good portion.
- Tamago-yaki: Osaka-style is thicker and sweeter than Kyoto-style — excellent comparison study

💡 Some Kuromon vendors have adjusted prices for the tourist crowd in recent years. A quick mental comparison of prices across two or three similar stalls before buying will serve you well.

Afternoon Tsutenkaku • Shitennoji • Abeno Harukas • Namba Yasaka Shrine

Tsutenkaku & Shinsekai

Tsutenkaku is Osaka's answer to the Eiffel Tower — not in scale, but in attitude. The current version (100 meters tall, rebuilt in 1956) stands at the center of the Shinsekai district, the city's most authentic slice of postwar Osaka working-class culture.



Tsutenkaku Tower — landmark of Osaka's Shinsekai district

Shinsekai itself is the draw: kushikatsu (deep-fried skewers on sticks) restaurants line every alley, the neon signs are decades old, the atmosphere is jovial and unpretentious. The golden rule of kushikatsu: the communal dipping sauce at your table is for ONE dip per skewer. Never double-dip. This rule is posted everywhere and enforced with genuine Osaka indignation if violated.

Shitennoji Temple

Founded in 593 CE by Prince Shotoku, Shitennoji is one of Japan's oldest official temples and

one of the first centers of Buddhism in the country. Unlike Kyoto's famous temples that draw tourist hordes, Shitennoji is primarily a place of actual daily worship — local Osakans light incense, pray, and move on with their days. There's a quality of lived religion here that more famous sites sometimes lack.

Namba Yasaka Shrine

The most visually startling shrine in Japan, possibly. The main hall is fronted by an enormous lion head stage — mouth wide open, teeth bared, easily two stories tall, staring you down from the entrance. This is not subtle architecture. The lion represents devouring evil and bestowing victory, and the visual is pure Osaka: nothing shy about it. Even if you only stop for 10 minutes, it's worth going out of your way to see.

Evening Shinsaibashi — Final Shopping Run

The last evening of the trip, and the primary goal is: buy everything you haven't bought yet.

- ▶ Shinsaibashi-suji: 580-meter covered shopping arcade, flagship stores for major brands, fashion, and lifestyle goods
- ▶ Matsumoto Kiyoshi (Matsukiyo): Japan's biggest pharmacy chain — face masks, eye drops, sunscreen, skincare, over-the-counter medicines
- ▶ Don Quijote (Donki): 24-hour discount store selling everything from electronics to snacks to costumes. Famously chaotic and genuinely fun. Deep-dive the snack section for trip-specific limited edition flavors.
- ▶ Bic Camera / Yodobashi Camera: Electronics, cameras, and appliances with tax-free shopping for tourists

🌙 The Dotonbori area convenience stores stock excellent regional snack options past midnight — the 7-Elevens and FamilyMarts near the canal often get limited-edition items that don't appear in regular stores. Night shopping in Osaka has its rewards.

DAY 7 | : Flying Home

The last morning carries that familiar travel melancholy: equal parts "I'm exhausted and miss my bed" and "I can't believe it's over already."

If you have an afternoon or evening flight, the morning is yours. Osaka's kissaten (old-school coffee shops) culture is excellent — find a "pure kissaten" (純喫茶) that's been running for decades, order a morning set (モーニング: coffee, toast, soft-boiled egg for usually 400–600 yen), and sit in the comfortable time-warp atmosphere of Showa-era Japan for one last slow hour.

Head to Kansai Airport 3 hours before departure — weekends and peak season mean longer security and immigration queues than you expect. Take HARUKA or the Limousine Bus, confirm your platform/stop the night before.

Final airport moves:

- ▶ Japanese whisky at duty-free (Yamazaki, Hakushu, Nikka — prices here are often significantly lower than back home)
- ▶ Last-call premium matcha powder from the specialty tea counter
- ▶ Regional Kansai snacks for colleagues (this is not optional — you will regret not buying enough)

At the departure gate, before boarding, look out the window at the runway and the distant water. Seven days, hundreds of kilometers walked, more food eaten than can be accounted for, more photos taken than will ever be organized into albums. And the overwhelming feeling: not enough time. There's never enough time.

That's how you know it was the right trip.

Essential Reference Guide

Getting Around

Airport to City

- ▶ JR HARUKA Express: Direct to Kyoto (75 min) and Osaka Umeda (50 min). Buy the ICOCA & HARUKA package in advance.
- ▶ Limousine Bus: Slower but goes directly to major hotels. Good if you have large luggage and a hotel not near a major station.
- ▶ Kintetsu Limited Express: Good option for Nara connections.

Kyoto City

- ▶ City Bus 1-Day Pass: ¥700 (confirm current price before travel — it increased in 2024). Most temples and shrines are on bus routes.
- ▶ Subway 1-Day Pass: ¥600. Efficient for north-south and east-west cross-city movement.
- ▶ ICOCA Card: Works on all buses, subways, and trains. Load ¥5,000+ at the start.
- ▶ Eizan Electric Railway: The narrow mountain train to Kibune and Kurama. Unmissable on its own for scenery.

Between Cities

- ▶ Kyoto ↔ Osaka: Hankyu Kyoto Line or JR, about 30–40 minutes
- ▶ Kyoto ↔ Nara: Kintetsu Kyoto Line express, about 35–45 minutes
- ▶ Kyoto ↔ Uji: JR Nara Line, about 20–30 minutes
- ▶ Osaka ↔ Nara: Kintetsu Osaka Namba Line express, about 35–40 minutes

Budgeting

Category	Budget (JPY)	Recommendations
Breakfast	¥300–600	Convenience store, kissaten morning set
Lunch	¥800–1,500	Teishoku set, ramen, udon
Dinner	¥1,500–3,500	Izakaya, yakitori, okonomiyaki
Snacks & sweets	¥500–1,000	Street food, matcha desserts, wagashi
Special dining	¥2,000+	Hikiniku to Kome, Nakamura Tokichi
Daily transport	¥700–1,200	Day pass or ICOCA tap payments
Temple admissions	¥300–1,000 each	Budget ¥3,000–5,000 total for week

Day-by-Day Quick Reference

Key Destinations	Critical Notes
Kansai Airport → Kyoto	Buy ICOCA, exchange yen, light dinner
To-ji · Kinkaku-ji · Arashiyama · Nishiki · Gion	Enter Nishiki by 16:30 — most stalls close by 17:30
Kiyomizu-dera (6am) · Hikiniku queue · Kibune · Dinner	At Hikiniku before 8am; aim for 17:00 dinner slot
Fushimi Inari (6am) · Nara · Uji	6am for Inari; allow 2–3 hrs in Uji
Move to Osaka · Katsuoji · Castle/Umeda · Dotonbori	Check Katsuoji bus return times!
Kuromon · Tsutenkaku · Shitennoji · Shinsaibashi	Donki open 24h for last-night shopping
Return flight	Arrive airport 3 hrs early; duty-free whisky

Accommodation Guide

Kyoto hotels should be booked 3–6 months in advance for sakura season (late March to early April) and koyo season (mid-November). For January travel, 1–2 months is usually sufficient.

- Near Kyoto Station: Best for transport convenience. All lines originate here. Good value business hotels in the ¥8,000–15,000/night range.
- Shijo-Karasuma area: Walkable to Nishiki, Gion, and Kyoto's main entertainment district. Mid-range to boutique options.
- Sanjo/Kiyamachi: Along the Kamo River, lively at night, excellent restaurant access. Slightly more expensive.

- ▶ Machiya guesthouses: Traditional wooden townhouses converted into accommodation — atmospheric and memorable, but book months in advance. Budget ¥15,000–30,000/night.
- ▶ Osaka (Dotonbori/Namba area): Good value, extremely central for food and shopping, easy access to Kansai Airport.

Essential Apps

- ▶ Google Maps: The single most important app for this trip. Download offline maps for Kyoto, Nara, and Osaka before you leave.
- ▶ Norikae Annai (Transit Japan): More detailed transit information than Google Maps for edge-case connections.
- ▶ Google Translate: Camera translation mode is a lifesaver for menus, signs, and product labels.
- ▶ Tabelog: Japan's primary restaurant review platform. Search any area and filter by category to find quality local spots.
- ▶ Yahoo! Weather Japan: The most accurate weather forecasting for Japan, particularly useful for planning outdoor temple visits.

Packing List

- ▶ Passport (obvious but worth stating — people have forgotten)
- ▶ ICOCA or SUICA card (or buy at airport)
- ▶ Yen cash — recommended ¥30,000–50,000 for the trip, depending on shopping plans
- ▶ Compact umbrella (light rain possible; January in Kyoto can surprise you)
- ▶ Hand warmers (kairo) — invaluable at outdoor shrines in January wind
- ▶ Grip-soled walking shoes — Kyoto's stone paths are beautiful and slippery when wet
- ▶ Foldable tote bag — for the inevitable overflow of shopping
- ▶ Copy of travel insurance documentation
- ▶ Small bills and coins — vending machines, bus fares, and temple admission booths often require exact change



A Final Word

On the flight home, I opened my photo roll and scrolled from the beginning: the five-story pagoda of To-ji catching the first morning light, the gold of Kinkaku-ji blazing against winter sky, the long tunnel of orange torii on Fushimi Inari at six in the morning, the deer of Nara bowing back when I bowed to them, the lanterns of Kibune Shrine under a thin dusting of snow, the moment Hikiniku to Kome's Hamburg steak was placed on the griddle, the matcha tea jelly in a bamboo vessel at Nakamura Tokichi, the Glico man running endlessly above the Dotonbori canal at midnight...

What the photos can't hold: the cold air in the bamboo grove at Arashiyama, the hollow echo of a single drum at an empty temple at dawn, the particular sound of geta (wooden sandals) on stone in Gion, the smell of cedar and incense and old wood that is the smell of a real Japanese shrine.

Those things live in memory, not in files. They're the reason you go. They're the reason you'll want to go back.

Kyoto rewards slowness. The more you rush, the less you'll see. Give yourself permission to stop at the gate that catches your eye, to follow the alley that looks interesting, to sit at the river for twenty minutes doing nothing at all. The best moments of any Kyoto trip happen slightly off the planned route.

Travel safe, eat well, and walk until your feet tell you things your mind hasn't figured out yet.



— A traveler who walked until their feet gave out and still didn't want to come home

◆ End ◆